

group, where Tharoor had few supporters. P. Chidambaram was not amused by Tharoor's earlier tweets on visa restrictions suggested by the home ministry while Mukherjee and A.K. Antony, who had been briefed by Tharoor earlier, spoke at length about how the episode had created a furore in Parliament and damaged the clean image of the Government. Still aglow from his international travel, the prime minister was more keen to talk about his favourite Nuclear Liability Bill rather than the liabilities of one of his ministers.

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**THAROOR AT HIS CONSTITUENCY
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM**

Later that night, Manmohan summoned Tharoor once again to his residence and told him to bring along his resignation. A disheartened Tharoor came up with a schoolboyish excuse saying that he had already sent his driver home. A PMO aide told the unwilling minister that a car would be sent to ferry him across.

Interestingly, when he had met the prime minister in the morning, Tharoor did not offer to resign, as any other seasoned Congressman would have. This was a grave political faux pas in Congress politics. Already the Congress leadership watched with a collective raised eyebrow when, right in the middle of the crisis, Tharoor had appeared on TV and, flipping back his hair, announced that he would not resign. Perhaps, Tharoor was under a

Home Truths

He may have lost his ministry but in Kerala Tharoor is still a hero

The biggest irony of the Shashi Tharoor saga is that the person who feels most vindicated by his loss of ministerial status is his mother, Lily. "He has no clue of Indian politics and he may face his first major setback here," she used to say. Tharoor insisted he was only carrying out the wish of his late father Chandran Tharoor, a journalist who wanted his son to serve the country. Not just his relatives, but most people in Kerala sympathise with him. "He is very intelligent and clean. But wrong advisors and an element of adventurism did him in," says R. Jeeva Kumar, who was Tharoor's personal secretary. T.P. Srinivasan, former Indian Ambassador says, "I have known him for 20 years. He never faced any charges of financial irregularity."

Tharoor's political rivals, however, feel he was guilty of financial and moral turpitude. "Tharoor has betrayed the faith reposed on him by the voters," says P. Ramachandran Nair, CPI leader who lost to Tharoor in Lok Sabha polls. The BJP wants him to resign as an MP as well. Tharoor won the Lok Sabha election by a huge margin thanks to the anti-Left wave and his "Mr Change" image. "People were thirsty for change as they were fed up with the all too familiar looks and language," Tharoor said. However, since then, his image has been on the wane mainly because of expectations being too high and remaining unfulfilled. Voters were disappointed as the former minister, despite his proximity to Sonia Gandhi and the prime minister, could not keep his electoral promises. The last word comes from Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan, "I wish he did something for our people under the BPL (Below Poverty Line) than trying to bring the IPL to Kochi."

by M.G. Radhakrishnan

false cushion of protection. He was one of the few Congressmen invited to think-tank meets at Rahul Gandhi's residence. He shared a PLU rapport with the Congress president who had smiled at the uproar following Tharoor's cattle-class tweet and told him that her husband too had been similarly misunderstood. But even someone as politically well cushioned as P. Chidambaram had immediately tendered his resignation after the recent Naxal attack. Tharoor remained oblivious to the political nuances of his situation. This was the same mistake made by Natwar Singh, during UPA's first term when he was implicated in the Volcker scandal. Like Tharoor, he refused to resign and instead flaunted his proximity to 10 Janpath. In the Congress, perception is everything and the moment the scandal threatens to engulf the leadership the offender is

ruthlessly brushed aside.

The Thiruvananthapuram MP had begun his maiden innings on a glorious note. His global credentials and wry wit made him the toast of Lutyen's Delhi. Even when he introduced the Suddenly Sunanda to the Capital's drawing rooms, it only added to his flamboyant image. He lamented about lack of humour among the country's political class, and middle class India nodded sympathetically. He tweeted about eating *chaat* at prime ministerial get-togethers and his digital constituency devoured his words. But smart lines can only take you that far. Maybe Tharoor should have listened more carefully to BJP MP Venkaih Naidu who had warned him at the start of the budget session, "Mr Minister, too much twitting will lead to quitting."

with Shafi Rahman